# EY Technology Risk

Forage Simulation

## Complete Documentation of Key Learnings

Task 1 to Task 4 — From Concept to Practice

**EY | Shape the future with confidence**

Program: *A Day in the Life of Technology Risk*
Platform: Forage (Ernst & Young)
Duration: 4 hours
Date: April 2026

This document brings together the full set of learnings from the simulation: IT fundamentals, professional skepticism, probing questions, and teamwork.

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# Foreword

## What is this simulation?

The *EY Technology Risk* simulation (available on Forage) is a 4-hour immersive program that closely reproduces the day-to-day work of a technology risk professional at Ernst & Young. It covers the core skills expected from a junior *IT Auditor* or *Technology Risk Consultant* in a Big Four firm.

The simulation is structured into **4 progressive tasks**, each one reinforcing the next.

| No. | Task | Skills developed |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | Understanding IT processes | Financial vs. IT audit, P2P/O2C cycles, ITGCs, application risks |
| 2 | Interacting with the business | Professional skepticism, cognitive biases, interview analysis |
| 3 | *Probing Questions* | Questioning techniques, application change-flow auditing |
| 4 | *Team Work* | High-performing teams, group dynamics, leadership |

**Guiding thread**

These four tasks form a coherent whole: Task 1 provides the vocabulary; Task 2 provides the mindset; Task 3 provides the investigative tools; Task 4 provides the collective posture needed to apply them effectively.

# 1

# Task 1 — Understanding IT Processes

## 1.1 The Audit Duo: Financial vs. IT

The first skill developed is the ability to distinguish between two types of audit that work hand in hand in every organization.

| Dimension | Financial Audit | IT Audit |
|---|---|---|
| Object | The figures, the financial statements | The systems that produce those figures |
| Core question | "Are the figures accurate?" | "Is the engine producing those figures reliable?" |
| Analogy | The *output* (the result) | The *engine* (the machine) |
| Typical risk | Error in the balance sheet | Unauthorized access to the accounting system |

**Key insight**

These two audits are complementary and hierarchical. If an *IT Auditor* discovers that access controls over the accounting software are ineffective, this directly undermines the reliability of the figures produced — and therefore the financial audit itself. IT Audit is the foundation of trust in the numbers.

## 1.2 Business Processes vs. IT Processes

### 1.2.1 Business Processes — The "What"

These are the sequences of activities that keep the business running. They describe **what the company does** to create value.

**Canonical example — Order-to-Cash (O2C):**
Customer places an order → Warehouse ships goods → Invoice issued → Cash collected.

**Associated risk:** if the software calculates VAT incorrectly, recorded revenue is misstated.

### 1.2.2 IT Processes — The "How"

These are the activities used to manage the environment in which business processes operate. They describe **how** systems are maintained, secured, and updated.

**Canonical example — Access Provisioning:**
Ensuring that only the right people can access the O2C system.

**Associated risk:** a disgruntled employee changes the "Amount Due" field to $0.00 in the database.

### 1.2.3 The P2P vs. O2C Diagram

The two business cycles most frequently audited are *Purchase-to-Pay* (P2P) and *Order-to-Cash* (O2C). They represent, respectively, cash outflows and cash inflows within the company.

Figure 1 — P2P (cash outflow) vs. O2C (cash inflow)

| | **Purchase-to-Pay (P2P)** | **Order-to-Cash (O2C)** |
|---|---|---|
| Cash direction | Outgoing — Expenses | Incoming — Revenue |
| Domain | Procurement & supplier payments | Sales & customer receivables |
| Key steps | Requisition → PO → Receipt → Invoice → Payment | Order → Delivery → Invoicing → Collection |
| Main risk | Fraudulent payment, duplicate payment | Unrecorded revenue, unpaid receivable |

## 1.3 Risks and Controls

A risk is "what could go wrong." A control is "what is done to prevent or detect it."

### 1.3.1 Three Types of IT Risk

- **IT Application Risk:** the software contains a bug — a transaction is processed twice, or a business rule is implemented incorrectly.
- **IT Data Risk:** the data is inaccurate. *Garbage In, Garbage Out*: incorrect data produces incorrect financial reporting.
- **IT Infrastructure Risk:** a server failure makes the system unavailable, blocking all operations.

### 1.3.2 IT General Controls (ITGCs) — The Foundational Trio

ITGCs are foundational controls. If these controls do not work, nothing else holds.

| **ITGC Pillar** | **Core question** | **Examples of controls** |
|---|---|---|

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| Manage Access | "Who gets in?" | Password policies, access approvals, MFA |
| Manage Change | "Who changed the code?" | Testing procedures, CCB, update approvals |
| IT Operations | "Is the system running?" | Backups, job scheduling, monitoring |

**Memorable analogy**

Business controls (a manager approving a check) are like a ticket inspector on a train: they verify each transaction one by one.
ITGCs (the guard at the station entrance, the lock on the server room) are like the security of the station itself.
A ticket inspector protects no one if anyone can walk into the control room and change the rail switches.

# 2

# Task 2 — Interacting with the Business: Professional Skepticism

## 2.1 The Three Theoretical Pillars

### 2.1.1 Professional Skepticism

**Definition.** Professional skepticism is an attitude of questioning combined with a critical assessment of evidence. It is not distrust of the auditee — it is the refusal to accept information without checking its reliability, source, and internal consistency.

### 2.1.2 System 1 vs. System 2 (Kahneman)

Daniel Kahneman describes two modes of thinking. In audit, the challenge is to remain in **System 2** even under time pressure.

| | **System 1 — Reflexive** | **System 2 — Analytical** |
|---|---|---|
| Nature | Fast, automatic, intuitive | Slow, deliberate, logical |
| In audit | Accepting what the auditee says | Questioning, testing, and independently verifying |
| Danger | Complacency bias, *priming* | Requires effort and active discipline |
| Objective | To identify it and avoid it | To cultivate it systematically |

### 2.1.3 The Four Cognitive Biases to Identify

- **Groupthink:** following group consensus without questioning it in order to avoid conflict.
- **Confirmation bias:** looking only for information that confirms what one already believes.

- **Automation bias:** placing blind trust in systems or reported figures without testing them.
- **Complacency bias:** prioritizing a good relationship with the auditee over analytical rigor.

## 2.2 Analysis of the Interview Scenarios: Jenna vs. Arianna

**Context:** Jenna (a junior EY auditor) interviews Arianna (IT Director, in role for 15 years) about IT change control. They have known each other through several audit cycles.

### 2.2.1 Scenario 1 — Approach and Mindset

**What Jenna says:** "Thank you for meeting with me. I'm sure nothing has changed, but as you know, we have to check every year."

**Mistake:** Jenna uses an apologetic tone and primes Arianna's response by suggesting that "nothing has changed." She therefore discourages the disclosure of any incident.

**EY correction:** a neutral, open-ended question with no assumption: "Can you walk me through the most significant changes that occurred in your systems this year?"

### 2.2.2 Scenario 2 — Interview Technique

**What Jenna says:** "Do you still review all changes migrated to production every month?" — Arianna's answer: "Yes."

**Mistake:** this is a closed yes/no question that reveals nothing about **how** the review is performed, **by whom**, or **on the basis of which documentation**.

**EY correction:** an open funnel question: "Can you explain how you perform the monthly review of changes moved into production?"

### 2.2.3 Scenario 3 — Excessive Trust in the Auditee

**What Jenna does:** Arianna states that the process has not changed, and Jenna takes notes without asking for any supporting evidence.

**Mistake:** Jenna falls into complacency bias and automation bias. In audit, management's statement is never sufficient on its own.

**EY correction:** always ask for documentary evidence: ticket samples, approval logs, system screenshots, policy extracts, and timestamps.

**Operational rule**

In audit, a statement is a starting point — never the conclusion. A process is not considered under control until its design and operating effectiveness have both been evidenced.

# 3

# Task 3 — Probing Questions and the PayNow Change Flow

## 3.1 Why Probing Questions Matter

A probing question is a question that goes beyond the first answer. It seeks to uncover the real process, test consistency, and identify where risk can enter the control chain.

A good probing question:

- is open enough to make the interviewee explain the process,
- is precise enough to target a control objective,
- leads naturally to documentary evidence,
- helps detect gaps, contradictions, or segregation-of-duties weaknesses.

## 3.2 The PayNow Application Change Lifecycle

The simulation uses the example of *PayNow*, a payroll application. The auditor's objective is to understand how a change moves from the initial request to production deployment, while ensuring that each step is controlled.

**Audit objective**

The goal is not merely to understand the process. The goal is to identify whether an unauthorized, untested, or poorly deployed change could affect payroll calculations and therefore create a financial misstatement risk.

## 3.3 Box A — Change Request Initiation

Every change begins with a request.

| Probing question | Auditor's reasoning |
|---|---|
| How are change requests initiated? | The auditor wants to know whether requests are formally captured or raised informally. |
| Who can submit a change request? | If anyone can submit a request without restriction, there is a risk of unauthorized changes. |
| How is the request logged and tracked? | A change without a trace cannot be audited afterward. |
| What information is required in a request? | A complete request should include rationale, business impact, risk level, and approval trail. |

## 3.4 Box B — Development and Testing

Once the request is approved, the change is developed and tested.

| Probing question | Auditor's reasoning |
|---|---|
| Who develops the change? | The auditor checks whether developer access is limited to authorized personnel. |
| In which environment is development performed? | Development should not occur directly in production. |
| How is testing performed? | The auditor wants to confirm the presence of structured test evidence. |
| Who validates the test results? | If the developer validates their own work, segregation of duties may be compromised. |

## 3.5 Box C — User Acceptance Testing (UAT)

Before deployment, the business must confirm that the change meets operational needs.

| Probing question | Auditor's reasoning |
|---|---|
| Who performs UAT? | UAT should be carried out by business users, not by IT alone. |
| How is UAT approval documented? | A verbal sign-off is insufficient for audit purposes. |
| What happens if UAT fails? | The auditor assesses whether there is a controlled rework loop. |

| | |
|---|---|
| How do you ensure the tested version is the version approved? | This checks the integrity of the code between testing and approval. |

## 3.6 Box D — Change Advisory Board (CCB)

Before a change goes live, it may need to be reviewed by a governance body.

| **Probing question** | **Auditor's reasoning** |
|---|---|
| Which changes require CCB approval? | Not all changes carry the same level of risk; approval thresholds matter. |
| Who sits on the CCB? | The auditor verifies whether the board includes the right functional representation. |
| What documentation does the CCB review? | Governance is only meaningful if it is based on complete information. |
| How are emergency changes handled? | Emergency procedures are a common point of control breakdown. |

## 3.7 Box E — Production Deployment

Approved changes are deployed into the production environment.

| **Probing question** | **Auditor's reasoning** |
|---|---|
| How is it ensured that no unauthorized change is introduced into the approved code? | The code validated by the CCB must match the code that is actually deployed. |
| How are changes deployed, and by whom? | Deployment should be performed by authorized personnel without the ability to alter the code. |
| How many instances of the application exist in production? | If multiple instances exist, all must be updated consistently. |
| If more than one instance exists, how is update consistency ensured? | A forgotten instance creates a critical inconsistency in the payroll system. |

**What the EY / AIM model adds**

1. **Systematic documentary evidence** — "Where is this documented?" A statement is never enough.
2. **Segregation of duties** — the person who develops must not be the one who tests. The person who tests must not be the one who deploys.
3. **Integrity of the code custody chain** — the window between UAT approval and deployment is a real and often overlooked attack vector.

# 4

# Task 4 — Team Work: High-Performing Teams

## 4.1 The 5-Pillar Model (Patrick Lencioni)

A high-performing team rests on a pyramid in which each level is the necessary condition for the next. This model, drawn from Patrick Lencioni's *The Five Dysfunctions of a Team*, structures team culture at EY.

1. **Trust** — vulnerability, admitting mistakes without fear.
2. **Healthy conflict** — passionate and respectful debate of ideas.
3. **Commitment** — buy-in to the collective decision.
4. **Accountability** — peer-to-peer correction.
5. **Results** — prioritizing shared goals.

| Pillar | Description | EY application |
|---|---|---|
| 1. Trust | Foundational base. It enables vulnerability and the admission of mistakes without fear of judgment. | Telling your manager that you do not understand a concept without fearing a loss of credibility. |
| 2. Healthy conflict | Debating ideas passionately without making it personal. | Challenging a senior's methodology in a client meeting while maintaining mutual respect. |
| 3. Commitment | Supporting the final decision, even after an initial disagreement (*disagree and commit*). | Backing an approach chosen collectively even if you would have done it differently. |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| 4. Accountability | Peers calling out performance or behavior issues when standards slip. | Calling out a colleague who does not document evidence according to EY standards. |
| 5. Results | Prioritizing collective objectives and client success over individual interests. | Client success comes before ego and individual career interests. |

## 4.2 The 5 Key Behaviors Selected

In the Task 4 exercise, five behaviors were identified as priorities for turning an ordinary group into a high-performing team:

1. **Drawing out ideas:** leaving no one behind — every voice contributes and helps prevent *groupthink* (a direct link to Task 2).
2. **Discussing controversial issues:** addressing difficult problems instead of avoiding them in the name of artificial harmony.
3. **Clarity of priorities:** ensuring that each team member knows exactly what to do, by when, and at what expected quality level.
4. **Valuing strengths:** recognizing and leveraging individual strengths to optimize collective effectiveness.
5. **Honesty about mistakes:** openly acknowledging one's own errors so the team can learn from them and avoid repeating them.

## 4.3 Final Crossword — Knowledge Synthesis

The crossword in Task 4 summarizes and connects all the learnings from the program.

| **Clue** | **Answer** | **Connection within the simulation** |
|---|---|---|
| *Effective interviewers ask . . . questions* | **PROBING** | Task 3 — Probing questions, funnel technique |
| *Professional . . . is the key to success* | **CURIOSITY** | Foundational trait of a Technology Risk professional |
| *. . . thinking is necessary for skepticism* | **CRITICAL** | Task 2 — Critical thinking, Kahneman's System 2 |
| *. . . is being effective and efficient* | **PRODUCTIVITY** | Task 4 — Priorities, focus, and team effectiveness |
| *. . . is power and leads to confidence* | **KNOWLEDGE** | Task 1 — Mastery of IT fundamentals |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| *. . . and proactively learning is necessary for growth* | **LEARNING** | Proactive learning throughout the simulation |
| *On-the-job . . . is the most effective form of learning* | **EXPERIENCE** | The simulation itself as a learning vehicle |

**Traits required of a Technology Risk professional**

Proactive learning • Professional curiosity • Probing questions • Critical thinking • Professional skepticism • Teamwork

# Conclusion — What Was Really Learned

## Summary of skills acquired

This simulation developed the core skills expected from a junior *Technology Risk Consultant* in a Big Four firm. Below is what was truly acquired, task by task, with concrete evidence of each learning outcome.

| Skill | Evidence of acquisition |
|---|---|
| IT mapping | Ability to distinguish financial audit from IT audit, position P2P vs. O2C, and identify precisely where a risk lives within a process. |
| Professional skepticism | Identification of Jenna's four biases, mastery of the System 1 / System 2 switch, and reformulation of problematic questions. |
| Change auditing | Structured and reasoned probing questions for each stage of the PayNow flow (Box A–E), covering the full application change lifecycle. |
| Teamwork | Mastery of the Lencioni model (5 pillars), selection of high-performance behaviors, and reconnection with anti-*groupthink* reflexes. |
| Communication | Ability to connect learning points across tasks and explain concepts in a clear, structured, and memorable way. |

Closing synthesis

"A Technology Risk professional must combine the rigor of an auditor, the intuition of an analyst, the curiosity of an investigator, and the mindset of a team collaborator. Technique without skepticism is blind. Skepticism without technique is powerless. And both, without the team, are insufficient."

— Synthesis of learnings, EY Technology Risk Simulation, Forage 2026

**EY | Shape the future with confidence**

Technology Risk Program

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